

Incident report: Fake Photoshop installer, Ahefi-linked artifacts, and Hekodex propagation on Instagram and Discord

Independent defensive case study · 8 October 2026 · Version 1.0 · Public/redacted edition

Executive finding: A Windows host was compromised after running a counterfeit Photoshop installer. Malwarebytes recorded active malicious processes, persistence, a Defender exclusion, and classified the initial installer as `Spyware.InfoStealer.Electron.Generic`. **Seven unusually specific process/task/service identifiers exactly match** a separately published Ahefi-associated victim report, although the four compared executable SHA-256 hashes are **different**. The victim reports that compromised **Instagram and Discord** accounts both sent a promotional crypto link to `hekodex[.]com`. A shared criminal operator, exfiltration server, or identical malware build **has not been established**.

Scope and evidence handling

This case is based on privately supplied Malwarebytes scan logs dated 6 October 2026, owner-observed account incidents, file hashes, reverse-engineering artifacts and screenshots from isolated VirtualBox Windows/Kali VMs, and independent public reports. Personal names, handles, email addresses, phone numbers, tokens, and victim-specific directory names are intentionally omitted. No malware executable is distributed with this publication.

Evidence grades: **Observed** = local forensic artifacts or first-hand victim report; **Corroborated** = cross-checked against public source; **Hypothesis** = plausible but unproven. Self-reported external cases are not independently authenticated by this author. There is **no packet capture from the originally compromised host**.

Timeline

Date	Event	Evidence grade
6 Oct 2026	Victim executed a counterfeit Photoshop27Full.exe	Observed / Malwarebytes detection
6 Oct, 14:31	Malwarebytes scan flagged 23 findings , all quarantined	Observed / original scan report
After infection	Unauthorized access and loss of control involving Instagram and Discord, with Google security alerts	Victim-observed
After compromise	Both Instagram and Discord were used to distribute a <code>hekodex[.]com</code> crypto-promotion link	Victim-observed
6-7 Oct	Accounts secured, sessions revoked, Windows reinstalled from clean media	Victim-observed
7 Oct	Later MSI sample analyzed in an isolated VM with Sysmon, Procmon, PE disassembly and Node/N-API hooks	Laboratory evidence

Original-host findings

The original Malwarebytes report documented the following suspicious executables and persistence entries:

Indicator	Type	SHA-256
Photoshop27Full.exe	Original fake installer; InfoStealer detection	6a4ebb1eb8c91f9eb89cb4059269be601758bbea911efa24e223263bdd4ae137
ProManagerc7e51.exe	Trojan.Crypt	388967831f49e57486244a4614cb6e71870478418e8c74ef0551d87b5c882ebf
ProUpdate7dd338.exe	Trojan.MalPack.PES	567b50a6e1f2e123d0b96f7a9ff4891097b6cbf90a8676e9b96f99010ed2df76
NetHost1dcc90.exe	Backdoor.Agent	5e19d99333b1d5f48c17a56b76436221d97c59ee416a3a2bdc4255abdbb1cc90
AppManagerServicef7ad.exe	Malware.AI detection	bbe1c6043618cd389e158774747cb9d73b02eb9d541ff4b8a67808af18e3ac2c

Persistence: scheduled tasks `UpdateHost_1117` and `MaintainHost_058f`; Windows service `CheckManager_29ce`. The logs also show an exclusion for `SVCHOST.EXE` under Windows Defender's process exclusions. The detections and subsequent account incidents substantiate serious compromise but **do not by themselves establish which individual cookies/passwords/documents were stolen or their destination**.

Ahefi correlation: matching artifacts, non-matching binaries

A public account from a user who installed the Ahefi VS Code extension [1] lists **exactly the same seven full identifiers**, including alphanumeric suffixes:

`NetHost1dcc90.exe` · `ProManagerc7e51.exe` · `ProUpdate7dd338.exe` · `AppManagerServicef7ad.exe` · `CheckManager_29ce` · `MaintainHost_058f` · `UpdateHost_1117`.

This is strong evidence of **shared artifacts or deployment conventions** between the cases. It does **not** prove the same infection vector or a single operator. Importantly, the other reporter's hashes do not match the locally recovered binary hashes:

Binary	Local SHA-256 prefix	Ahefi reporter SHA-256 prefix [1]
NetHost	5e19d993...	bb2e245a...
ProManager	38896783...	de13c9db...
ProUpdate	567b50a6...	7ad335cc...
AppManagerService	bbe1c604...	c211c902...

A separate static analysis of Ahefi v1.0.4 [2] describes a Windows-targeted extension that retrieves encrypted payload configurations from a remote endpoint and executes retrieved code. This establishes a plausible **delivery model**, not that this victim installed Ahefi, not that the Photoshop installer called `ahefi[.]com`, and not that a given executable is identical.

Hekodex: cross-platform account abuse, not proven C2

The victim reports promotional messages containing `hekodex[.]com` were sent by **both compromised Instagram and Discord accounts**. A Reddit post on 5 October [3] reported a suspicious crypto link sent by a known Instagram contact; an independently published analysis [4] associates the domain with a comparable crypto-promotion/MrBeast-themed scam. Domain reputation snapshots [5] report registration on **3 October 2026**, Cloudflare delivery and differing detection counts across scanners and times.

The observed role of `hekodex[.]com` is **social engineering / scam promotion through hijacked accounts**. There is **no direct evidence** that it was used to collect stolen cookies or served as malware command-and-control. Cloudflare edge IPs must not be used to infer an underlying server owner.

Isolated laboratory investigation of the later MSI

Two separately downloaded ZIP archives had different overall archive hashes, but each extracted to the **same** `Photoshop27Full.msi` with SHA-256 `86d0759c3fb2c1ec6e40c5c4518a6641e37d806a422880ee66feb62f256304e4` (19,820,544 bytes). This MSI differed at the file level from the original `.exe`; equivalence of their full infection chains was not established.

The MSI identified itself as `WoodPoint Excel Export`, launched Node 12, executed an obfuscated `y.js`, and produced a transformed `clik5o3.js`. Execution showed dynamically created native Node N-API addons loaded into `node.exe`, then a binary PE payload:

MSI → node.exe / y.js → clik5o3.js → first N-API addon → second N-API addon → 388,112-byte PE input

Recovered lab artifact	SHA-256
Native addon, 309,248 bytes	<code>a8f8016f2f91ee3c4df9e9fc67f861c4aeaa960f70e89d51704822fd6022a756</code>
Native addon, 317,440 bytes	<code>0fcfa35275a5afbac12d483230c4d1cd9fc4e8bc3ec0798323ece06a27a4603e</code>
Extracted PE32+ x64, 388,112 bytes	<code>0d75e404a160b180039257aa1d16f36d2732d60bc281cfc4e411517cb07c7001</code>

The native addons export obfuscated JavaScript-callable functions (`kjtt61h2k`, `gx1qtfyj`, `wvvc0sf52`, and others). Static traces of the first addon reach BCrypt hashing primitives, consistent with validation/unpacking; this is **not proof of credential theft**. The second addon received the PE buffer and the observed execution ended with `Error: h`; the root cause was not established.

Network-test limitation: The VM was restricted to VirtualBox Internal Network `malnet` with no real outbound route; Kali simulated DNS and HTTP endpoints. No malware-attributed DNS/HTTP transaction or accesses to decoy Chromium `Login Data`, `Cookies` and `Local State` files were observed in those runs. Such negatives concern **only the code path exercised**, and do not exonerate the sample.

Confidence matrix

Claim	Assessment
Windows compromise, persistence and Defender modification	Observed
Information-stealer label on original installer	Observed AV classification ; behavior not fully reconstructed
Seven exact identifiers shared with an Ahefi-associated report	Cross-source corroborated
Same binary builds as the Ahefi report	No; SHA-256 values differ

Claim	Assessment
Hekodex links sent from compromised Instagram and Discord accounts	First-hand victim report
Ahefi and Hekodex run by the same actor	Unproven
Hekodex as exfiltration/C2 destination	Unproven
Exact stolen data or original exfiltration endpoint	Unknown
Original EXE and later MSI deploy identical payloads	Unproven

Response guidance

Isolate impacted hosts, preserve logs/hashes, rebuild the OS from trusted media when appropriate, and review/purge startup tasks, services and Defender exclusions. From a known-clean device, rotate passwords and API keys, revoke **all existing sessions/tokens**, reconfigure 2FA if required, verify account recovery channels and recent security actions, and alert recipients of messages sent from hijacked Instagram or Discord accounts. Do not execute recovered binaries on a live workstation or visit the defanged scam domain to “test” it.

Indicators of compromise

Machine-readable entries are provided in `indicators.csv`. **IOC scope matters:** hash matches identify specific builds, while filenames/task names may be reused or differ in other infections. `hekodex[.]com` is designated **propagation/scam-domain IOC, not exfil/C2**. `ahefi[.]com` is **public Ahefi distribution context**, and was not observed on this victim's original host.

Sources and limitations

[Local-1] Malwarebytes original-host scan, 6 October 2026 at 14:31, provided privately by victim; public edition redacted. **[Local-2]** Full Malwarebytes scan, 6 October 2026. **[Lab]** VM logs, Sysmon, Procmon, PE analysis and screenshot/transcript evidence, supplied by victim.

1. Public Ahefi victim report: https://www.reddit.com/r/malwares/comments/1wpbhu7/from_my_brothers_wake_to_getting_infected_by_ahefi/
2. Independent Ahefi v1.0.4 analysis (25 September 2026): <https://linux.sb/topic/23801>
3. Hekodex scam inquiry (5 October 2026): https://www.reddit.com/r/antivirus/comments/1wygj7r/mrbeast_hekodex_crypto_scam_question/
4. Hekodex social-engineering analysis (6 October 2026): <https://howtoremove.guide/hekodex-com-scam-casino/>
5. Domain reputation snapshots: <https://scanner.pcrisk.com/scan-results/hekodex.com> and <https://tools.malwaretips.com/url-scan/hekodex.com>
6. Related counterfeit Photoshop promotional repository (not evidence of its owner being the operator): github.com/stormkazekagematch/adobe-ps-v27-core.

Publication ethics: This report intentionally omits identifying victim information, executable samples, passwords, tokens, precise user directory paths, and unsupported personal attribution. This is a defensive incident report, not an accusation that specific individuals or the Ahefi and Hekodex domain owners are one actor.